

“In the digital age, speed often beats truth.”

Prod-a-thon

Understanding **Trust** Breakdowns in **Viral** Digital Content

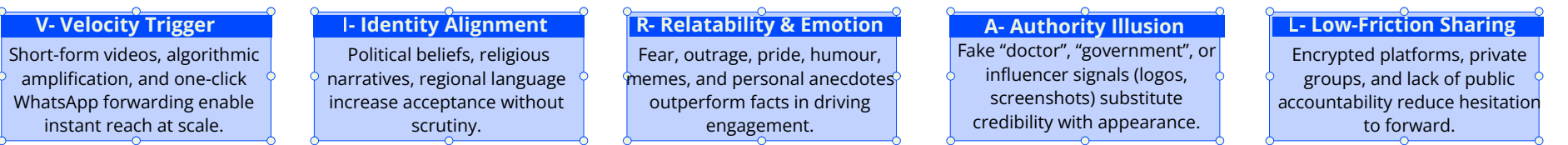
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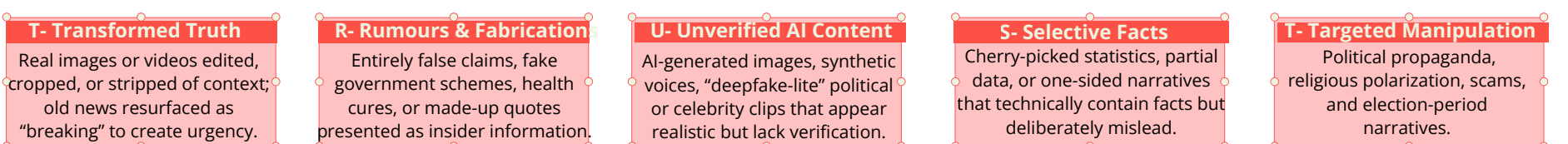
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Trust Breakdown Loop in India's Digital Ecosystem

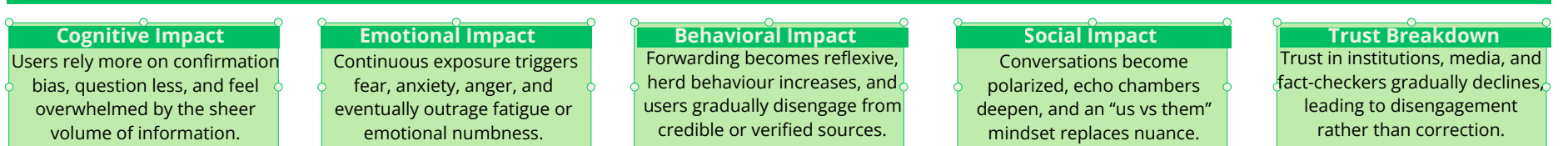
Drivers of Content Virality (Why Content Spreads Fast)



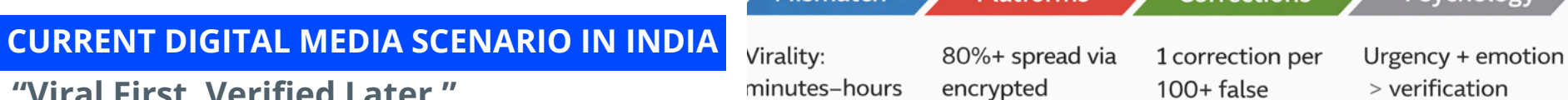
Types of Misleading Content (What Goes Viral)



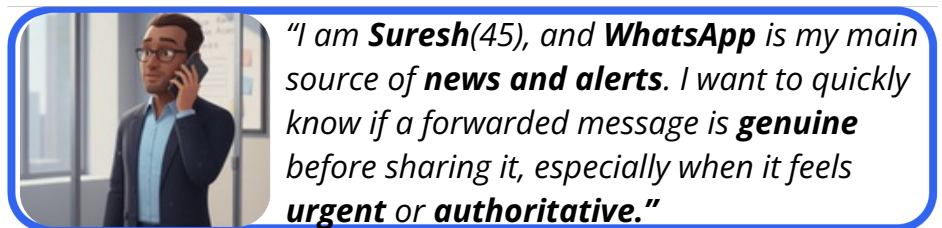
Psychological Impact on Users (What It Does Over Time)



Why Regulation Alone Fails



1.WhatsApp-First Information Sharer



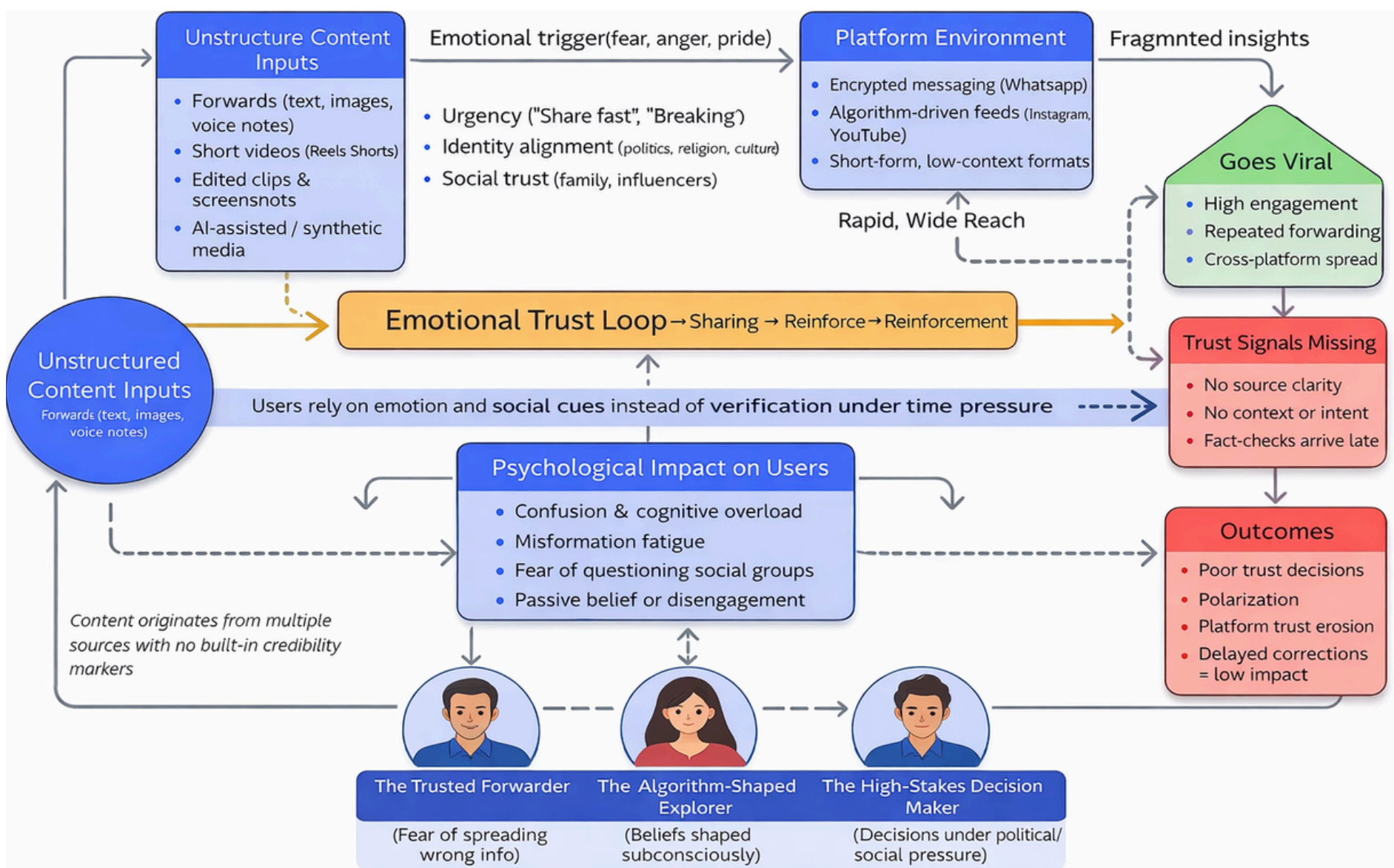
"I am **Suresh**(45), and **WhatsApp** is my main source of **news and alerts**. I want to quickly know if a forwarded message is **genuine** before sharing it, especially when it feels **urgent** or **authoritative**."

What they want

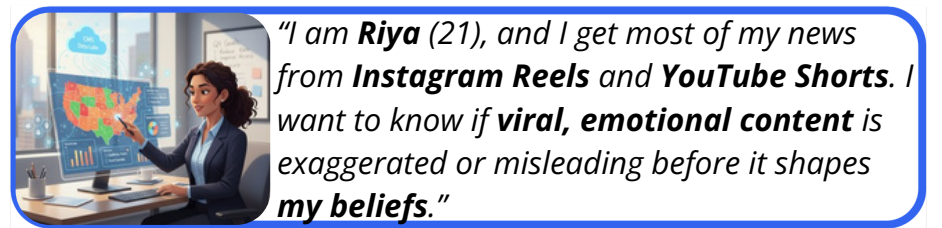
🎯 To quickly judge whether a forwarded message is genuine before sharing it further —especially when the content feels urgent, authoritative, or socially sensitive.

Why trust fails

- ⚠ Messages appear **credible** due to familiar senders and **official-sounding** language
- ⚠ End-to-end **encryption** prevents visible **verification** signals
- ⚠ **Fact-checks** arrive after content has already spread
- ⚠ Fear of **disrespecting elders** or group norms discourages **questioning**



2.The Algorithm-Shaped Explorer

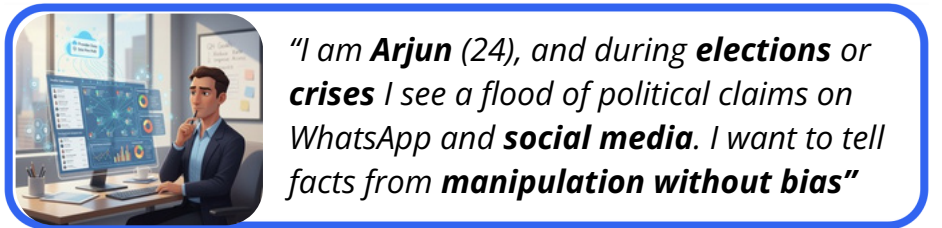


"I am **Riya** (21), and I get most of my news from **Instagram Reels** and **YouTube Shorts**. I want to know if **viral, emotional content** is exaggerated or misleading before it shapes **my beliefs**."

🎯 To understand whether viral, emotional, or trending content is exaggerated, biased, or misleading before it shapes their opinions or beliefs.

- ⚠ Algorithms reward **emotional** and **sensational** content over accuracy
- ⚠ Short-form formats remove context and nuance
- ⚠ Blurred **boundaries** between facts, opinions, satire, and sponsored content
- ⚠ No lightweight, in-feed trust cues during consumption

3.Politically Aware Digital Citizen



"I am **Arjun** (24), and during **elections** or **crises** I see a flood of political claims on WhatsApp and **social media**. I want to tell facts from **manipulation without bias**"

🎯 To distinguish factual information from propaganda or manipulation in real time—without being nudged toward a particular political viewpoint

- ⚠ Conflicting **narratives** circulate simultaneously across platforms
- ⚠ Misinformation spreads **faster** than **corrections**
- ⚠ Fact-checking feels **delayed, selective, or biased**
- ⚠ High **emotional intensity** reduces critical **evaluation**



Thank You

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